



Foreword

Like many people, my early enthusiasm for history focused on particular dates and events: 1588 and the defeat of the Spanish Armada; the battle of Waterloo in 1815; the fall of Constantinople in 1453. Some had personal connections: July 1, 1916, when my grandfather, serving as an artilleryman, lost several of his closest friends on the first day of the Somme offensive.

From the earliest times, history was cast as a grand chronicle of events and actions, the work of often larger-than-life protagonists, and was intended to enthrall and capture the imagination in the same way as a great novel. But during the 20th century, academic historians grew skeptical about the “history of the event.” Most often the events were battles, treaties, and political struggles, a narrative that excluded the lives of the great majority of men, women, and children. In reaction to this, historians focused on cultural, social, and economic continuities, looking for their evidence in everyday objects, trading records, accounts of childhood and old age. The result was certainly a richer and more diverse account of human experience, but one that often left little sense of change over time.

As the present book shows, history constructed on a timeline does not have to be a narrow account of war and conquest, treaties and treason. All of these feature here, but so do the dates of intellectual and technological innovations, the creation of key works of art, crucial shifts in patterns of agriculture,

exploration, and commerce. This is an exhilarating and comprehensive account of human creativity as much as its destructiveness, of discovery and understanding as well as natural disasters and human folly. Spectacularly illustrated and succinctly explained, key events in history from the first beginnings of agriculture to the most recent astrophysical discoveries are laid out along what is probably the most comprehensive timeline ever assembled.

No less exciting for me in helping to compose this book and to choose from all facets of human history to build up the timeline, is the contribution that *History Year by Year* makes to an understanding of global history. Throughout the book, events, discoveries, and achievements occurring in Europe and North America are set against the equally momentous and significant events in the Mideast and East Asia, India, Africa, or South America and the Pacific Rim. This is a history that stimulates awareness of a wider world by placing events from across that world side by side and reminding us that progress and discovery, feats of social organization, and challenges to a political status quo are no monopoly of the Western world, but as likely to originate in India or Egypt as in France and Spain.

The design of this book offers a unique opportunity to appreciate a global history of mankind in all its facets. I hope that you enjoy reading *History Year by Year* and using it as a reference as much as we enjoyed planning and writing it.

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Lost city of the Incas

Perched 7,970 ft (2,430 m) above sea level, in the Peruvian Andes, the Inca citadel of Machu Picchu was probably constructed in the 15th century, and abandoned in the 16th.